HEARTWOOD OF THE BODHI TREE



The Buddha's Teaching on Voidness

BUDDHADĀSA BHIKKHU

Edited by Santikaro Bhikkhu
Original translation from the Thai by Dhammavicayo

WISDOM PUBLICATIONS
BOSTON

10

Contemplating Dependent Co-origination

We have discussed the spiritual disease from which we all suffer, and we have examined the nature of *suññatā*, which provides our cure. Now we will consider the steps we can take to treat our disease. Both in protecting against the disease and in its treatment, there must be the principle of allowing no involvement with "I" and "mine." But how is one to go about it? There are many methods.

With physical and mental diseases, one ailment can be treated in a variety of ways. We need not rely on a single fixed method, but whatever the method, the aim and the result must be the same—good health. Similarly, in treating the spiritual disease, the Buddha taught a great number of practices in order to answer the needs of different people, times, places, and occasions. So we have heard of a great number of practices with many names, and perhaps we have been frightened to hear that he established eighty four thousand subjects of Dhamma (*dhammakhanda*). Now, if there were truly eighty four thousand topics, we would all feel discouraged. We would die before we learned them all; nobody can learn them all. We would learn some, forget, and then have to learn them again, only to forget again, or else they would get completely mixed up in our minds. Fortunately, there is merely one handful, merely one subject, which the Buddha summarized in the one phrase, "Nothing whatsoever should be clung to as 'I' or 'mine'." To hear this subject is to hear all subjects. To practice it is to practice everything. And to receive its fruit is to be cured of all disease.

Every one of the many methods for wiping out the di[illegible]

ıd "mine" works. Which one you use depends on how you wish
practice.

ependent Co-arising

ne way is to constantly contemplate "I" and "mine" as illusions
hallucinations (*māyā*). This practice will enable you to see that
e feeling of self, a seemingly solid entity that we are familiar with
"I" and "mine," is in fact a mere illusion. This insight is
hieved by contemplating self in terms of dependent co-origina-
on (*paṭicca-samuppāda*).

To explain *paṭicca-samuppāda* theoretically or technically takes a
ng time. It could take one or two months to cover just this single
sue. This is because, in the field of theory, it's been turned
creasingly into a psychological and philosophical subject, so that
has reached a state of excessive complexity. Yet, in the field of
ractice, *paṭicca-samuppāda* is, as the Buddha said, just a single
andful. When there is contact with a form, sound, odor, flavor, or
her sense object at one of the sense doors, that contact is called
phassa" in Pali. This *phassa* conditions feeling (*vedanā*). *Vedanā*
onditions craving (*taṇhā*). *Taṇhā* conditions clinging (*upādāna*).
pādāna conditions becoming (*bhava*). *Bhava* conditions *jāti*,
hich is "birth", and following from birth there is old age, sick-
ess, and death, which are *dukkha*.

Please see that as soon as consciousness (*viññāṇa*) meets with a
nse object there is sense contact, and that the subsequent condi-
oning of *vedanā*, *taṇhā*, and so on, is called *paṭicca-samuppāda*.
ependent co-origination is the process by which various things—
isting in dependence on other things through the influence of
norance (*avijjā*)—condition the arising of new things, which in
rn condition the development of further things, and so on and
n. This process or stream is called *paṭicca-samuppāda*. It is a
ependent co-arising wherein no self is to be found, merely depen-

dence followed by arising. *Paṭicca-samuppāda* is this process of dependent co-arising or dependent co-origination, which conditions *dukkha*.

Two Methods

The way to benefit from this teaching is not to allow the dependent co-arising to take place. One method for doing this is to cut the process off right at the moment of sense contact. Do not allow the development of *vedanā*, do not allow feelings of satisfaction or dissatisfaction to arise. When there is no production of *vedanā*, there is no birth of the craving and clinging that is the "I" and "mine." The "I" and "mine" lie right there at the birth of craving and clinging; illusion lies right there. If *paṭicca-samuppāda* is stopped just there at the moment of sense contact, when there is nothing but sense contact, there is no way for the "I" and "mine" to arise. Then, there is no spiritual disease and no *dukkha*.

If this first method is not possible, there is another method. For the average person, it is extremely difficult to prevent sense contact (*phassa*) from developing into *vedanā*. As soon as there is sense contact, the feelings of satisfaction or dissatisfaction always follow immediately. The process doesn't stop at *phassa* because most of us have never been trained in Dhamma. But there is still a way to save ourselves: when *vedanā* has already developed, although there is already a feeling of satisfaction or dissatisfaction, stop it right there. Let feeling remain merely as feeling and then pass away. Don't allow it to go on and concoct *taṇhā*, foolishly wanting this and that in reaction to the satisfaction and dissatisfaction. Once there is satisfaction, there is desire, craving, indulgence, possessiveness, envy, and their string of consequences. Once there is dissatisfaction, there is the desire to harm, to hurt, to devastate, and even to kill. If there are these sorts of desires in the mind, it means that

edanā has already concocted *taṇhā*. In this case, one must suffer rom the spiritual disease of *dukkha*, and nobody can help. All the ods together cannot help. The Buddha said that even he cannot elp. He has no power over the Law of Nature; he is merely the ne who reveals it, so that others can practice in accordance with . If one practices correctly, one doesn't suffer. Thus, it is said, if *edanā* has concocted *taṇhā*, nobody can help. As soon as any form f craving has arisen, there inevitably must be *dukkha*.[42]

In that turbulent wanting that arises in the mind, see how to distinguish the feeling of the "desirer," of "I," of the self or ego which wants this or wants that, which wants to do it like this or like that, which has acted in this way or that, or which has received the esults of those actions. That one who desires is "I." Wanting hings, it grasps them as "mine" in some way or another: "my" status, "my" property, "my" safety, "my" victory. In all of those feelngs the "I" is also present.

The feeling of "I" and "mine" is called *upādāna* (attachment), which arises from *taṇhā* (craving). *Taṇhā* conditions *upādāna*. If *paṭicca-samuppāda* has progressed as far as *taṇhā* and *upādāna*, the germ that entered through the eye, ear, nose, tongue, or body has matured to the extent that it expresses itself as the symptoms of the disease, because *upādāna* is followed by existence (*bhava*). *Upādāna* conditions the arising of *bhava*. *Bhava* means "having and being." The having and being of what? The having and being of "I" and "mine." *Kammabhava* is the action (*kamma*) that conditions the arising of "I" and "mine." If it is called simply "*bhava*," it means the state of "I" and "mine" full blown, the disease full blown.

Just Experiencing

In our practice we must stop the process right at the point where sense contact (*phassa*) conditions *vedanā*, or, if we fail there, we must prevent *vedanā* from concocting *taṇhā*. After that it's hope-

less. We try to have Dhamma right there at the meeting of eye and forms, of ear and sounds, of tongue and flavors, and so on, by continually training in the fact that nothing whatsoever should be clung to. With ordinary people, once sense contact takes place, *vedanā* arises followed by *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, *bhava*, and *jāti* (birth). This is a path so well worn that it is extremely easy to follow.

Now, try not to take that path anymore. As soon as there is sense contact, turn around and take the path of mindfulness and wisdom. Don't take the path of "I" and "mine." Or, if you follow it as far as *vedanā*, try to turn back from there to the path of *sati-paññā*. Don't just float along with the stream of "I" and "mine." In this way, there is never any *dukkha*, neither day nor night. If we can practice skillfully, and perfectly follow the correct method to the end, we can realize Arahantship ourselves.

If we wish to go by the Buddha's words, there is an easy principle that the Buddha taught to a disciple named Bāhiya. "O Bāhiya, whenever you see a form, let there be just the seeing; whenever you hear a sound, let there be just the hearing; when you smell an odor, let there be just the smelling; when you taste a flavor, let there be just the tasting; when a thought arises, let it be just a natural phenomenon arising in the mind. When you practice like this, there will be no self, no "I". When there is no self, there will be no running that way and no coming this way and no stopping anywhere. Self doesn't exist. That is the end of *dukkha*. That itself is *nibbāna*."[43] Whenever life is like that, it's *nibbāna*. If it's lasting, then it's lasting *nibbāna*; if it's temporary, then it's temporary *nibbāna*. In other words, there is just one principle to live by.

Whatever method of practice you adopt, it should lead to equanimity or quenching regarding the sense objects that make contact. Whatever sort of insight meditation you do, if you do it correctly without deceiving yourself, it must take this one form, the identical form, that of not letting sense data be concocted into the feeling of "I" and "mine." Then, it's not difficult to destroy defilements

since, when you practice like this, they are destroyed as a matter of course.

To make a simple comparison, if we want to prevent rats from coming around and disturbing us, we keep a cat. All we have to do is look after the cat, and the rats will disappear without our having to catch them ourselves. The cat just goes about its business and there are no more rats. Because of the cat, the undesirable thing is no more.

Living Rightly

If we merely oversee the eyes, ears, nose, tongue, body, and mind in the proper manner, the killing of defilements occurs naturally. This is to speak in conventional terms. It is the same as in the Buddha's teaching, "Bhikkhus, if you live rightly, the world will not be without Arahants" (*Ime ce bhikkhave bhikkhū sammā vihareyuṁ asuñño loko Arahantehi assa*).[44] Pay close attention to this. Just live in the right way—you don't have to do anything more than that—and the world will not be void of Arahants. This is not a minor point.

"*Sammā vihareyyuṁ*" means "to live rightly." How is it to live rightly so that the world will not be void of Arahants? To live rightly is to live untouched by forms, sounds, odors, flavors, and physical sensations. In other words, they are experienced, but they do not enter and concoct feeling (*vedanā*), craving (*taṇhā*), and clinging (*upādāna*). Thus, we live intelligently. We live with mindfulness and wisdom, void of "I" and "mine," for we have studied enough and have practiced until we are sufficiently adept. So having made contact, the sense object dies like a wave breaking on the shore, just as if we have a cat in our house that kills the rats that enter from other houses or the forest.

If we live in the right way, according to the principles of non-clinging, forms, sounds, odors, flavors, and physical sensations

cannot harm us. We experience them and associate with them, but treat them with mindfulness and wisdom. Then, we can eat them, consume them, possess them, or keep them without *dukkha* resulting, just as if they don't exist. The result is the same as if we don't use them, don't eat them, don't keep them, because there is no "us" or "ours."

On the other hand, when everything is done with "I" and "mine," there is *dukkha* all the time. Even before consuming or keeping, there is already *dukkha*, and while actually consuming or keeping there is further *dukkha*. The whole thing becomes miserable due to this cause. To be vexed with the disease of *dukkha* is called "not living rightly."

When we live rightly, there is no way for the disease to arise. If we live rightly, the defilements (*kilesa*) have no food to sustain them. They must starve and die. Starving the defilements can be compared to caging a fierce tiger in a pen where there is no food. We don't have to kill it; it will die of its own accord. In the same way, we encircle and trap forms, sounds, odors, flavors, physical sensations, and mental phenomena right at the point where they contact the eyes, ears, nose, tongue, body, and mind. We cage them right there. If we practice correctly towards those things right there at the very point of contact, the defilements have no way to get food. The tiger of defilement starves to death. In other words, the germ of defilement can no longer breed further defilement or cause *dukkha*.

The Buddha taught that if we live rightly—simply live in the correct way—the earth will not be void of Arahants. This is called practicing according to the principle of *paṭicca-samuppāda* (dependent co-origination). It is the kind of right living by which defilements cannot arise, because we see that "I" and "mine" are mere illusions that only arise when sense contact gives rise to feeling, which then concocts craving. If the concocting of craving is avoided, clinging to "I" and "mine" does not take place.

You should understand correctly that "I" and "mine" is a prod-

uct of concoction; it's not real. It's an illusion in the same way that a wave arising from blowing wind is an illusion. The water is real and the wind is real, but the wave is an illusion. Here we use a material phenomenon for the sake of comparison, and the comparison is not perfect. We merely mean to indicate the illusoriness of a wave that arises due to concocting: the wind blows across the water, a ridge of water arises, and then it disappears. The feeling of "I" and "mine," which arises over and over in a day, is like a wave. The water of the sense experience is contacted by the wind of delusion or ignorance, and waves of "I" and "mine" are formed over and over again throughout the day.

Spiritual Birth

A single emergence of the feeling of "I" and "mine" is called one birth (*jāti*). This is the real meaning of the word "birth." Don't take it to mean birth from a mother's womb. A person is born from the womb once and gets laid out in the coffin once. That's not the birth the Buddha pointed to; that's much too physical. The Buddha was pointing to a spiritual birth, the birth of clinging to "I" and "mine." In one day there can be hundreds of such births. The number depends on a person's facility for it, but in each birth the "I" and "mine" arises, slowly fades, gradually disappears, and dies. Shortly, on contact with another sense object, "I" and "mine" arise again.

Each "birth" generates a reaction that carries over to the next. This is what is called "the old *kamma* of a previous birth ripening in the present birth," which is then transmitted further. Every birth carries on the process. This is how to understand the "fruit of action" (*kamma-vipāka*) and the reception of *kamma's* results. Such an interpretation agrees with the Buddha's own words; any other interpretation strays from the point. We must understand birth, *kamma*, and the fruits of *kamma* in the correct way. For

example, there can be birth as the desirer of some pleasing object, and then death followed by birth as a thief, and then a further death followed by birth as the enjoyer of that object. In a short time, there is birth as a prisoner in the dock. Then, guilt having been established, birth occurs as a convict in jail. These sorts of birth are many and muddled; they are like a multitude of threads tangled together. If you look closely, however, you will understand that if one stops birth, then at that moment there is *nibbāna*—that which is not born, does not age, does not sicken, and does not die. If there is still birth, still the feeling of "I" and "mine," the wheel of birth and death keeps turning as a continual cycle of *dukkha*.

We shouldn't think, however, that absence of birth means that one is so empty that there is no feeling at all. It does not mean sitting stiffly like a log of wood. On the contrary, one is extremely active. Being perfectly void of birth, void of "I," is to have perfect mindfulness and wisdom. Whatever one does is completely fluent. There being no false thinking, false speech, or false action, one acts swiftly and surely. There is no possibility of error because one's *sati-paññā* is natural and spontaneous. This state of mind is called "void of I." The person who is void of "I," who is *nibbāna*, can do anything and do it without error. Her or his actions are many, are extremely swift, and are greatly beneficial.

Don't think that this sort of experience makes you unable to do anything, that you'll just stop everything and be lethargic, weary, and indifferent. That's your own idea. Your foolishness makes you afraid of *suññatā*, afraid of *nibbāna*, afraid that ending your craving will be unpleasant.

In fact, the ending of craving is the ultimate pleasure and the greatest happiness. It is true pleasure and happiness. It is not harmful, deceitful, or illusory. The pleasure of the ordinary unenlightened person is false; it is deceitful, is illusory, and fills one with *dukkha*. It is like bait, which catches us on its hook when we

swallow it. Ordinary enjoyment of pleasure is called "falling into the hands of the devil." In such a state there is unceasing confusion. One is trapped on the wheel of birth and death, in the chain or the whirlpool of *dukkha*, unable to get free.

11
Sensory Illusions

Seeing the "I" and "mine" as an illusion, by practicing the principle of dependent co-origination (*paṭicca-samuppāda*) is one path to understanding *suññatā*. Now, we will consider another method: seeing that even the sense objects—forms, sounds, odors, flavors, tangible objects, and mental phenomena—are illusion. This second method involves an understanding of impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and not-self (*aniccatā*, *dukkhatā*, and *anattatā*).

Impermanence, Unsatisfactoriness, and Not-Self

We must not take the subjects of impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and selflessness lightly. They are not just issues for old people nor merely words to be chanted when someone dies. They are subjects that we all must take up and use in our everyday lives. Anyone capable of using their understanding of impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and selflessness to manage their daily life possesses the ultimate antibody. For such a person, forms, sounds, odors, flavors, and so on cannot turn into poison. Such a one has security (*khema*). Notice that the Buddha didn't use the word "happy," because that word can sometimes be misleading, or even deceptive. "Secure" is good enough. It means free and peaceful.

We should be clear about the meaning of "*khema*." It means "secure from the disturbances (*yogas*)."[45] To be secure from the things that disturb us is to be void, which is *nibbāna*. If you want a secure life, you must rely on a thorough understanding of impermanence, suffering, and not-self. Then, you can withstand the